Risky Outdoor Play Is Not a 0–3 Developmental Law

A systematic review finds associations between risky outdoor play and some health outcomes in children, mostly older than this atlas's window; it is not a toddler efficacy package or a license for unsupervised hazard.

-SCHOOL-AGE-ASSOCIATION; LOW-TO-MODERATE-0-3; LOW-TODDLER-PACKAGE | STATUS: DRAFT | DOMAIN: PLAY, HEALTH | REPL

WHAT WE KNOW (Narrowest Supported Conclusion)

Brussoni and colleagues (2015) systematically reviewed studies of risky outdoor play and health. The literature, largely school-age, reports associations with physical activity and some social and injury-pattern outcomes. It does not isolate risky play as a unique cause of later intelligence, self-control, or school success.

EVIDENCE AND CAUSAL ASSESSMENT

Systematic review, not an RCT of 0–3 outdoor play. Age bands, definitions of "risky," and outcomes vary. Adjacent: symbolic-pretend-play-emergence.md and pretend-play-educational-claims.md already refuse play-as-curriculum. Exploration (exploration-as-sampling.md) is a different identification. Screens are not re-theorized as outdoor's opposite.

EFFECT SIZE AND PERSISTENCE

No portable d for "risky play" in toddlers. Injury findings are mixed and definition-dependent. Persistence into later competence is largely untested in this atlas's window.

BIAS, HETEROGENEITY, AND CONFOUNDING

GI attenuation: untested-in-GI (no twin or sibling designs for 0–3 outdoor play; observational associations reflect family lifestyle selection).

School-age samples dominate. Families who allow more outdoor risk also differ in resources, neighborhoods, and supervision. Injury surveillance and play observation are not the same design.

WHAT THIS DOES NOT MEAN (Strict Boundary Conditions)

Outdoor play is not worthless. It is not a registered 0–3 intelligence or character program. Removing all challenge is not shown to be required, and unsupervised hazard is not a developmental necessity.

WHAT ACTION IS REASONABLY JUSTIFIED

Do not import school-age reviews as toddler laws. Safety and opportunity are both live Art. A risky-play product does not follow.

VERIFIED SOURCES & DOI IDENTIFIERS

- Brussoni et al. (2015), International Journal of Environmental Research and Public Health